represented the emergence of territorial kingdoms that ruled over people (*jana*). The king headed the government aided by a centralised administration. The king was also the sovereign ruler. The king levied taxes out of agricultural surplus and redistributed it and ensured maintenance of law and order in a hierarchical society by force and coercion. These features marked the formation of state in the Gangetic plains.

Sixteen Mahajanapadas

According to *Puranic*, Buddhist and Jaina traditions, there were sixteen *mahajanapadas*.

1. Gandhara
2. Kamboja
3. Asmaka (Assaka)
4. Vatsa
5. Avanti
6. Shurasena
7. Chedi
8. Malla
9. Kuru
10. Panchala
11. Matsya
12. Vajji (Vrijji)
13. Anga
14. Kasi
15. Kosala
16. Magadha

The *mahajanapadas* are classified as *gana-sanghas* and chiefdoms based on the nature of their polity.

Gana-Sanghas

The proto-states of the Gangetic region were known as *janapadas* and comprised chiefdoms, republics and small kingdoms. Sixteen *mahajanapada*s find mention in the early texts. There were also *gana-sanghas* or oligarchies, which were centred on clans. The Vrijjis were one of the best known of the *gana-sanghas*, and Vaishali was their capital in the Mithila region. These kingdoms did not come under the single decision-making authority of a king but decisions were taken on a collective basis by the heads of the different clans together. There were also smaller kingdoms such as Kosala and Kasi. It is interesting to note that the names of the clans, such as Ikshvaku and Vrishni, as well as these early kingdoms, are all mentioned in the two epics, Ramayana and Mahabharata.

Monarchies or Kingdoms

The *mahajanapadas* on the Gangetic plains were all monarchies. Vedic orthodoxy was an established practice in these kingdoms. The priestly class enjoyed a preeminent status in the *mahajanapadas* unlike in the *gana-sanghas.* The kingdoms were governed by kings and the administration was centralised. The brahman priests provided legitimacy to the king through various rituals. The kingship was hereditary and the succession was in most cases based on the law of primogeniture. The king was assisted by councils called *parishad* and *sabha.* The councils were advisory in nature. The king appropriated the agricultural surplus through land revenue apart from a few other taxes. *Bali* was a tax imposed based on the area of cultivable land. *Bhaga* was obtained as a share of the produce. *Kara* and *Shulka* were some of the other taxes collected during this period. Thus the king raised revenue through taxes to maintain an elaborate administrative structure and an army.

The richer landowners were called *grihapatis.* These landowners employed labourers called *dasas* or *karmakaras.* The smaller landowners were known as *kassakas* or *krishakas.* The society was stratified on the basis of *varna.* It emerged as a marker of status. Cultivators and artisans were identified as the *shudras*. A new social category that emerged during this period was placed below the *shudras* in the social hierarchy and considered untouchables. They were forced to live on the fringes of the settlements and subsisted on hunting and gathering their food. They were marginalised and given only menial jobs as urbanisation was on the rise. They had their own language, which was different from that spoken by the Indo-Aryans.

3.3 Emergence of Heterodox Thinkers

In the sixth and fifth centuries before the Common Era, north India underwent a remarkable intellectual awakening that profoundly impacted India and influenced

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